



Commission decides to refer Bulgaria to the Court of Justice of the European Union for failing to transpose EU rules on hired vehicles

Brussels, 1 October 2026

Today, the European Commission decided to refer **Bulgaria** ([INFR\(2023\)0192](#)) to the Court of Justice of the European Union for failing to transpose almost all measures of the Hired Vehicles Directive ([Directive \(EU\) 2022/738](#)) into national legislation.

This Directive sets minimum standards for the use of rented vehicles hired without drivers for transporting goods. The common standards can reduce costs and increase flexibility for businesses that transport goods by road. The Directive also ensures that companies can use a hired vehicle in other EU Member States than the one they are established in — as long as that vehicle meets all the applicable laws, safety rules, and other required standards in any Member State of registration. As hired vehicles tend to be newer than the average fleet, they are on average also safer and less polluting.

Member States had to transpose the Directive into national law and comply with its provisions by 6 August 2023.

As Bulgaria did not transpose the Directive by then, the Commission sent a [letter of formal notice](#) to Bulgaria in September 2023, and a [reasoned opinion](#) in December 2024. Since then, Bulgaria has notified some national transposition measures. However, the Commission services concluded that only one provision of the Directive, the one determining proof of compliance, has been transposed.

The Commission considers that efforts by the Bulgarian authorities have been insufficient and is therefore referring Bulgaria to the Court of Justice of the European Union, with a request of financial penalties.

Background

Directive (EU) 2022/738, amending Directive 2006/1/EC on the use of vehicles hired without drivers for the carriage of goods by road, is an integral part of the transport policy of the European Union and its internal market for road freight transport. It modernises and clarifies rules governing the hiring of vehicles without drivers for the carriage of goods by road.

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